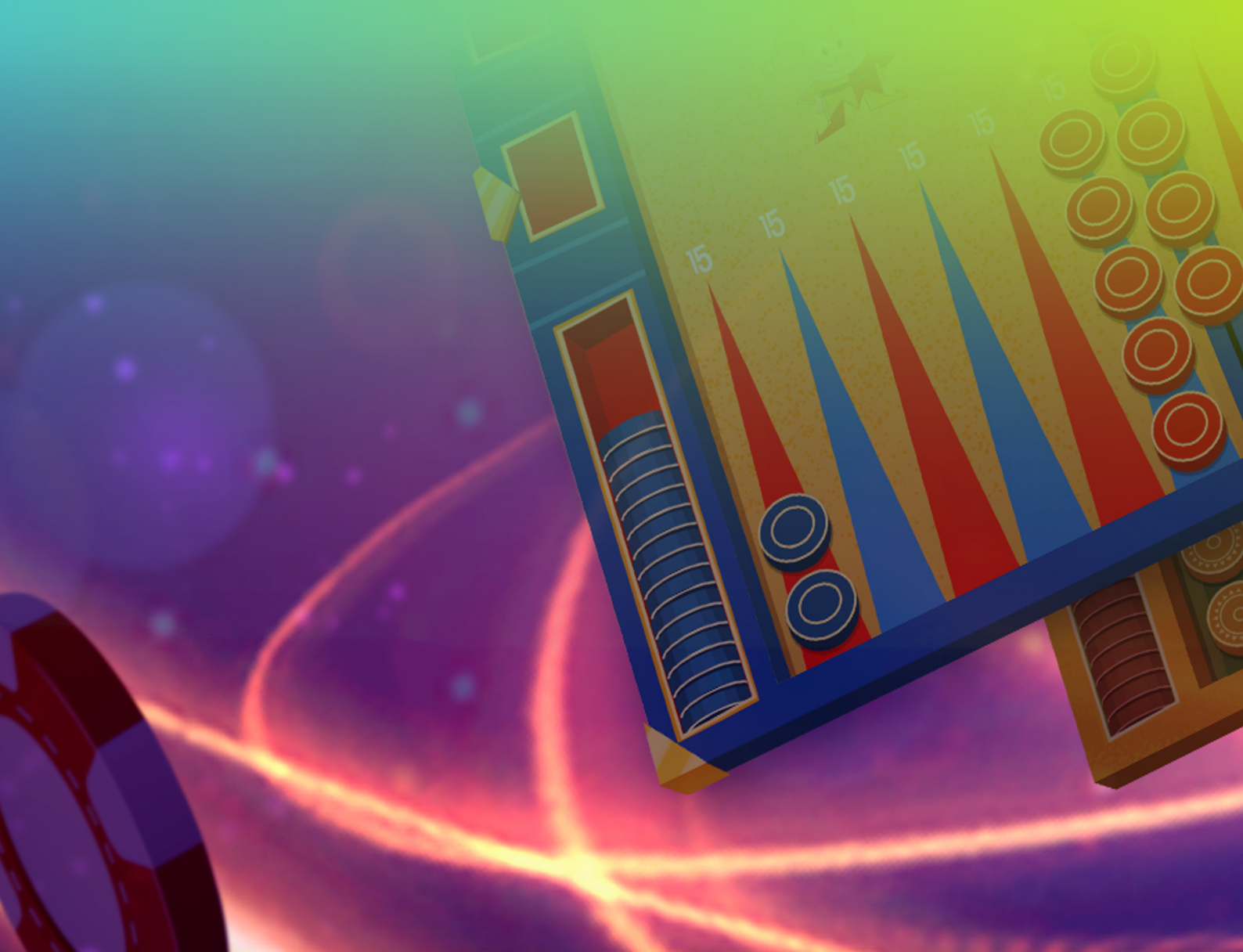


IG0741 – Indie Game Startup

# Acey Deucey

## **GAME DESIGN DOCUMENT**



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# Core Gameplay

## Game Mechanics

The core gameplay loop blends the strategic foundation of **Backgammon** with roguelike and deck-building systems to create a dynamic, replayable experience. Traditional dice-and-checker play is reimagined through modifiers, custom dice, and collectible upgrades that evolve with each run.

### Moment-to-Moment Mechanics

- Roll variable dice with custom faces or modifiers to determine checker movement.
- Play power-up cards such as “*Double Down*” or “*Swap Roll*” to manipulate dice outcomes or apply temporary effects to the board.
- Earn coins by winning matches and spend them in the shop to purchase themed dice sets, “joker” checkers, or rare variants like gold and stone pieces.

### Session-Level Loop

1. Enter a procedurally generated match featuring unique rule modifiers and opponents.
2. Defeat AI adversaries to earn currency and unlock new deck-building elements that persist across runs.
3. Advance through escalating tiers of difficulty, culminating in *Boss Boards* with distinctive mechanics or environmental effects.
4. Explore different themed boards—such as *Casino*, *Wooden Classic*, or *Tournament Mode*—each offering unique aesthetics and rule variations.

## Genre

*Acey Deucey* is a hybrid of a **Strategy Board Game** and a **Roguelike Deck-Builder**. It is rooted in the traditional mechanics of Backgammon yet reimagined through modern indie design sensibilities to appeal to both strategy enthusiasts and fans of procedural, replayable experiences.

- Features procedurally influenced dice rolls and rule modifiers that create a sense of unpredictability and strategic tension, reminiscent of *Balatro*.
- Incorporates collectible, deck-building progression systems inspired by games such as *Slay the Spire*, allowing players to construct personalized playstyles over multiple runs.
- Presents a stylized, casino-inspired aesthetic that reinforces its themes of risk, reward, and mastery over chance.

## Player Fantasy

### Hook

*"Master the dice — bend luck to your will."*

### Kicker

What if Backgammon rewarded cunning gamblers who could manipulate chance itself?

*Acey Deucey* fulfils the fantasy of transforming a game traditionally ruled by luck into one of deliberate mastery and foresight. Players experience the thrill of turning randomness into advantage—chaining combos, predicting outcomes, and outsmarting AI opponents through tactical use of cards, relics, and modifiers. Every decision reinforces the sensation of being in control of fate, embodying the archetype of a confident strategist at the digital casino table.

# Player Experience & Interaction

## Platform and Controls

### Platforms

*Acey Deucey* is designed for cross-platform release on **PC (Steam)** and **mobile devices** (*iOS* and *Android*). The mobile version features an adapted interface optimised for portrait orientation and single-handed play, while maintaining full feature parity with the desktop build.

### Controls

- **Mouse** and **touchscreen** input are used to move checkers, select cards, and interact with the interface.
- Core interactions use intuitive **drag-and-drop** gestures with animated visual feedback to communicate valid moves and actions.
- The minimalist UI prioritises clarity and speed, enabling comfortable play on both large and small screens without sacrificing strategic depth.

## Spatial Abstraction

*Acey Deucey* is presented on a **2D top-down board** rendered at a subtle isometric angle to enhance depth and spatial clarity. Each side of the board represents opposing player zones, divided into 24 triangular points consistent with traditional Backgammon layout conventions.

Custom boards introduce thematic and mechanical variety—such as *casino*, *wooden*, or *regional* designs—each integrating unique modifiers or environmental effects tied to the game's roguelike systems.

## Avatar

In *Acey Deucey*, the player is represented through their personalised set of **checkers** and a **deck of modifier cards**. Rather than controlling a physical character, the player assumes the role of a strategic overseer—a *tabletop tactician*—who shapes probability, positioning, and momentum through deliberate decision-making.

This abstract representation reinforces the game's theme of intellect over luck: the avatar is not a figure on the board but a presence behind it, embodying mastery, foresight, and control over the forces of chance.

## Camera Perspective

*Acey Deucey* employs a fixed, slightly angled **top-down 2.5D camera** that displays the entire board within view. This perspective preserves the clarity and familiarity of traditional Backgammon while adding visual depth through subtle parallax, lighting, and animation effects.

### Characteristics

- The camera remains **locked in place** during gameplay—neither panning nor rotating—to maintain clear spatial orientation and focus on strategic decision-making.
- Subtle screen shakes and zoom effects are used to highlight impactful moments such as dice rolls, checker captures, or card activations.
- Between rounds and within shop interfaces, UI elements transition smoothly using tweened animations to maintain a sense of flow and continuity.

# Game Systems & Dynamics

## Goals and Scores

The player's primary objective remains true to classic Backgammon: **clear all checkers from the board before the opponent**. However, *Acey Deucey* expands upon this foundation with a roguelike layer that introduces additional meta-goals and long-term progression systems.

- **Win Matches** to advance through procedurally generated tournament tiers and unlock new challenges.
- **Earn Currency** by completing matches, which can be spent on dice sets, special checkers, and relics within the in-game shop.
- **Build High Scores** across multiple runs, combining total earnings, victories, and risk multipliers into a persistent leaderboard metric.
- **Unlock Achievements** based on deck composition and play style (e.g., *"Win without rolling doubles"*), encouraging experimentation and replayability.

## Progression and Variety

Progression in *Acey Deucey* follows a roguelike deck-building structure, where each run represents a self-contained campaign of risk, reward, and discovery.

- Each run begins with a basic set of low-tier checkers and a standard dice set.
- Victories reward the player with new modifiers, relics, and upgrades that introduce powerful synergies and tactical diversity.
- Shops encountered mid-run offer strategic choices between immediate upgrades and long-term investments, balancing planning with adaptive play.

Variety is achieved through procedural and thematic systems that keep each session distinct:

- **Boss Boards** introduce unique environmental rules—such as frozen checkers, mirrored movement, or shifting points—that redefine the rhythm of play.
- Rotating rule sets inspired by regional Backgammon variants (*Portes*, *Plakoto*, *Fevga*) create familiar yet evolving challenges.
- Unlockable boards, dice styles, and house rules are earned through milestone achievements, reinforcing replayability and player mastery.

## Tension and Rest

*Acey Deucey* balances moments of high intensity with periods of calm, creating a rhythmic flow that mirrors the natural pulse of casino play—the cycle of risk and relief.

- **Tension:** Occurs during critical dice rolls, the activation of powerful cards, or when navigating high-stakes positional gambits on the board.
- **Rest:** Emerges in the quieter phases of play—planning moves, refining the deck between matches, or browsing upgrades in the in-run shop.

This deliberate alternation between pressure and recovery sustains engagement, preventing fatigue while amplifying the impact of each decisive moment.

## Obstacles and Penalties

The core challenges in *Acey Deucey* emerge from a blend of traditional Backgammon mechanics and roguelike unpredictability:

- Opponent checkers can block or capture the player's pieces, disrupting planned movements and forcing adaptive strategies.
- Randomised dice rolls introduce controlled chaos, which can be mitigated through the tactical use of cards and relics.
- Poor deck management may leave players without key modifiers, limiting their ability to recover from unfavourable rolls.
- Advanced AI opponents—modelled on grandmaster-level play—present escalating difficulty that demands effective use of modifiers and foresight to overcome.

Penalties reinforce the game's tension—reward loop, encouraging calculated risk-taking:

- **Loss of Resources:** Coins or cards are forfeited after a defeat, constraining future upgrades.
- **Card Debuffs:** Certain risk-heavy runs may inflict lasting penalties on cards or relics, echoing the "voucher" system from *Balatro*.
- **Run Termination:** Losing all matches results in a complete reset of progress—a classic roguelike permadeath mechanic that heightens stakes and replayability.

## Resources

Players must manage several interdependent resources that shape both short-term tactics and long-term progression:

- **Coins:** Earned after matches and used in the shop to purchase upgrades, relics, or new modifiers.
- **Dice Sets:** Customised collections that alter dice behaviour and influence doubling cube mechanics, allowing players to manipulate probability and risk.
- **Jokers:** Specialised checkers with unique properties—such as *stone*, *gold*, or *glass* variants—that modify standard movement or interaction rules.

Mastering these interconnected systems is essential for deep strategic play and for sustaining momentum during late-game boards, where efficient resource use can mean the difference between defeat and a high-scoring run.

## Decisions

Strategic decision-making is central to player engagement in *Acey Deucey*, blending tactical foresight with calculated risk-taking. Every choice shapes the outcome of a run, reinforcing the game's balance between skill, planning, and controlled randomness.

- **Modifier Management:** Choosing which deck-building cards or relics to purchase, upgrade, or discard during each run.
- **Risk Assessment:** Deciding when to take safe or aggressive rolls based on current position, modifiers, and dice probability.
- **Checker Placement:** Strategically positioning *jokers* and special checkers to double, block, or swap with maximum advantage.
- **Rule Selection:** Enabling variant rule sets or “mutators” that increase difficulty in exchange for higher rewards.

These layered decisions ensure that no two runs play the same, encouraging adaptive strategies and rewarding mastery over both chance and choice.

## Simulation and Chance

*Acey Deucey* preserves the inherent randomness of traditional Backgammon while introducing systems that let players partially influence probability and outcome. Deck-building modifiers can alter dice behaviour or probability directly, enabling effects such as “*reroll lowest die*,” “*flip result*,” or “*swap pips*”. These mechanics allow players to mitigate risk without fully removing uncertainty.

Procedurally generated board setups, shop inventories, and event sequences ensure every run feels distinct while maintaining overall balance. Each session is generated from a unique seed, allowing players to replay identical setups to test alternate tactics or optimise different strategies.

The result is a layered simulation—partly deterministic, partly emergent—capturing the tension of gambling within a system of fair, transparent randomness.

# Narrative & Presentation

## Storytelling

The narrative in *Acey Deucey* is minimal yet thematic, grounding its roguelike structure in a mythic reinterpretation of Backgammon's 5,000-year legacy. Rather than following a linear plot, the game presents an **adventure through time and chance**—a journey across symbolic boards that represent different eras, cultures, and philosophies of play.

### Story Arc

- The player ascends through a hierarchy of themed opponents—*The Dealer*, *The Oracle*, and *The Gambler*—each embodying a distinct philosophy of risk and reward.
- Rule variants introduced by these opponents reflect their personalities and challenge the player's command of both luck and logic.

### Storytelling Methods

- **Environmental Storytelling:** Narrative cues emerge through board design, background art, and surrounding objects that suggest each setting's culture and period.
- **Illustrated Interludes:** Short dialogue cards or stylised panels appear between matches, adding flavour and context without breaking gameplay flow.
- **Thematic Reinforcement:** Music, sound design, and relic descriptions subtly expand the game's mythos, ensuring that story remains integrated with play rather than separated from it.

## Art Direction and Style

### Visual Style

Designed for a mature audience, *Acey Deucey* adopts a visual identity that fuses the allure of casino culture with the refinement of vintage board-game craftsmanship. Glowing dice, metallic checkers, and bold, condensed typography evoke the atmosphere of slot machines and arcade cabinets while maintaining an elegant, high-end finish.

### Influences

- *Balatro* — for its pixel-art minimalism, card-based interface, and evocative use of texture and lighting.
- Classic *slot machines* — for their rhythmic animations, bright colour schemes, and visual feedback loops that signal risk and reward.

- *King of Thieves* — for its stylised cartoon presentation and playful use of contrast and motion to guide attention.

## Colour Palette

The palette is bold and saturated, reflecting the energy and temptation of casino design. Deep purples, golds, and teals convey sophistication and mystery, while accent tones of crimson and emerald signal danger and fortune. Each thematic board may employ its own variation of this palette, but all maintain a high-saturation aesthetic rooted in the visual language of poker tables, slot machines, and roulette halls.

## Animation and Visual Effects

Animation and visual effects in *Acey Deucey* serve to enhance feedback, communicate state changes, and heighten the sense of tactile engagement. Every motion is purposeful, designed to balance casino spectacle with the clarity of strategic play.

- **Checker Movement:** Pieces slide smoothly across the board using eased motion and subtle bounce physics to emphasise impact and precision.
- **Dice Rolls:** Dynamic, physics-driven dice animations convey randomness and authenticity, reinforcing the thrill of each roll.
- **Joker Effects:** Specialised shaders highlight the activation of joker checkers, reflecting their unique properties and status changes.
- **Board Reactions:** Environmental responses—such as cracks, sparks, and flashes—occur when powerful cards or relics are triggered, underscoring dramatic moments.
- **Elimination Feedback:** Optional “kill” animations for captured or removed checkers provide satisfying polish and visual closure to high-stakes moves.

Subtle motion design elements—such as idle board shimmer, rotating coins, or softly pulsing lights—maintain visual energy even during low-action phases, ensuring the interface always feels alive and responsive.

## Sound Design

Sound plays a crucial role in grounding *Acey Deucey*’s tactile and atmospheric identity. Backgammon is inherently a noisy game—dice clatter against wood, felt, or leather, and checkers strike the board with satisfying weight. The soundscape builds on these physical textures to create a sense of authenticity and immersion.

- **Dice and Board Sounds:** Each dice material—metal, glass, or stone—produces a distinct tonal quality when rolled. Surfaces such as wood, felt, or leather alter the resonance, reinforcing board variety and player feedback.

- **Joker Audio Cues:** Specialised sound effects distinguish different joker types, signalling their activation and unique abilities.
- **Music:** A single high-quality musical track underpins the experience, dynamically remixed and filtered to suit different game contexts—play, shop, and menu screens—similar to the adaptive layering approach used in *Balatro*.

The overall sound direction favours warmth and clarity over density, using subtle audio variation and dynamic filters to maintain focus while enriching the casino-like ambience.